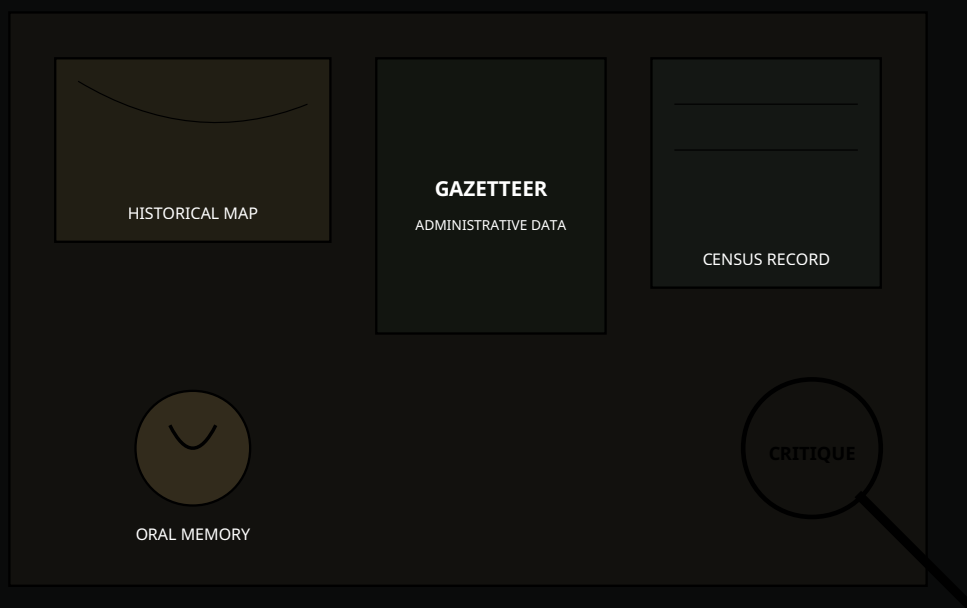


COLONIAL RECORDS & HISTORICAL SOURCES

“History survives in records—but records must be read critically.”

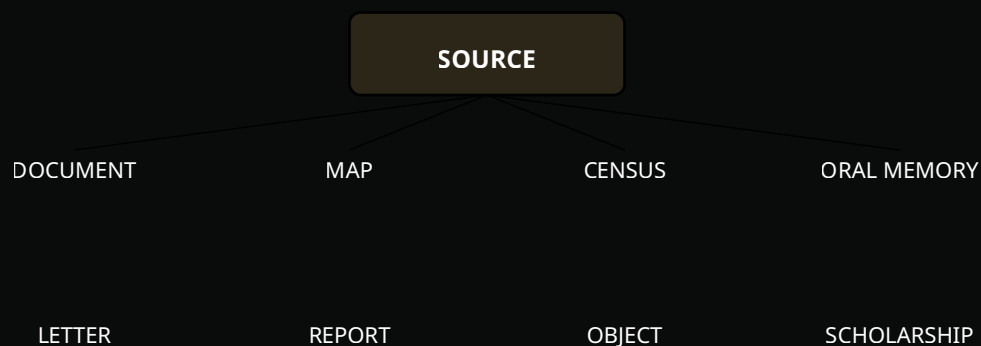
History does not arrive from the past as a finished story. It survives in fragments: a government report, a map, a census table, a gazetteer, a letter, a military dispatch, a photograph, a family document, a poem, a grave inscription, or a story remembered by an elder. Each source preserves something, but none preserves everything. For Orakzai history, this matters especially because much of the written record was produced by outsiders whose purposes were often administrative, military, political or geographical. To understand the record, we must therefore read not only what a document says—but also why it was written, who wrote it, and what it could not see.



“A conceptual visualization of the Orakzai historical archive: fragments of the past requiring critical research.”

WHAT IS A HISTORICAL SOURCE?

A historical source is evidence produced or preserved from which researchers can learn about the past. These sources are categorized based on their origin and nature, including primary documents, secondary interpretations, oral memories, and material objects. For the Orakzai, these sources provide the building blocks for reconstructing their history.¹



“The classification of historical evidence for Orakzai research.”

COLONIAL RECORDS

British India produced extensive written records about the North-West Frontier for administrative, political, military, and geographical purposes. These records, preserved in collections like the India Office Records at the British Library, include administration reports, tribal tables, and dictionaries of tribes. While they provide detailed data, they must be read within their institutional context, recognizing the administrative purpose behind their creation.^{1 2}

COLONIAL RECORD → ADMINISTRATIVE PURPOSE → SELECTIVE OBSERVATION → EVIDENCE

“The logical path from colonial administrative reporting to historical evidence.”

GAZETTEERS & TRIBAL TABLES

Gazetteers like the **Gazetteer of the Kohat District (1883-84)** were foundational primary sources, detailing geography, population, and tribal relationships. Tribal tables provided classification systems for administrative needs. While useful for names and locations, these categories often reflected a colonial worldview rather than local self-identification. Cross-checking these with local evidence is essential.³

COLONIAL CATEGORY ≠ COMPLETE LOCAL IDENTITY

A colonial document is evidence, but it is not automatically the truth. It reflects the categories and priorities of the administration that produced it. To achieve a richer history, we must use, contextualize, and compare colonial records with local memory and academic research.

WHO IS MISSING?

Archives often contain silences. The voices of women, children, ordinary farmers, and those who disagreed with authorities are frequently missing or marginalized in official reports. Reconstructing these missing dimensions requires looking beyond the formal archive to oral histories, material culture, and local community memories.⁶

VISIBLE VOICES (OFFICIAL ARCHIVE)

MISSING VOICES (SILENCES)

Women, Children, Non-Combatants, Dissenters

“Visualizing archival silences and the need for supplementary sources.”

ORAL HISTORY & MEMORY

Oral history is a serious research source that preserves family memories, migration stories, and community events missing from written records. However, memory is not a perfect recording; it changes over time and can be influenced by later events. Effective research requires dating, contextualizing, and cross-checking oral traditions with other independent evidence.⁶

EVIDENCE

+

INTERPRETATION

+

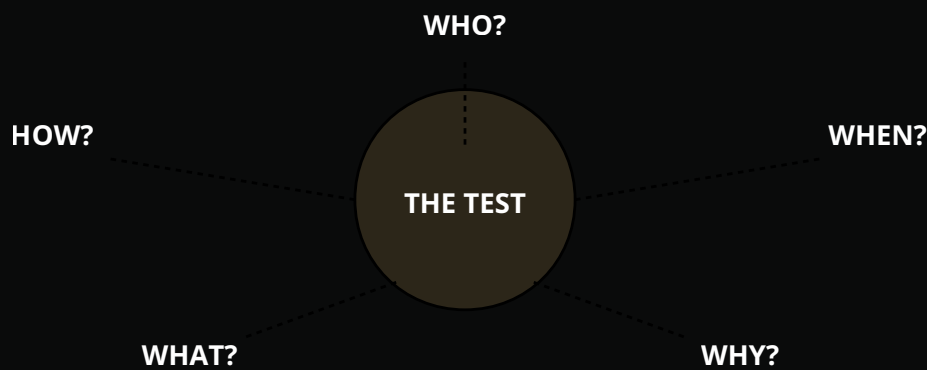
TIME

MEMORY

“The components of oral memory as historical evidence.”

SOURCE CRITICISM & CORROBORATION

The core of historical methodology is source criticism—evaluating the author, date, purpose, and bias of every record. Corroboration involves comparing multiple independent sources to establish confidence in a claim. One source is possible evidence; multiple independent sources provide stronger historical certainty.⁵



“The Five-Question Test for evaluating historical sources.”

SOURCE TYPE	STRENGTH	LIMITATION	BEST USE
Colonial Report	Precise dates/events	Administrative bias	Reconstructing state actions
Gazetteer	Detailed geography	Static categories	Locating settlements/clans
Oral History	Lived experience	Memory shifts	Internal community dynamics
Academic Study	Rigorous analysis	Interpretive framework	Synthesizing evidence

AI & DIGITAL ARCHIVES

Modern research utilizes digital archives and AI tools for OCR, transcription, and cross-referencing. However, AI can hallucinate and reproduce colonial biases without context. Responsible research treats AI as an assistant, not an authority, requiring human review and verification of original archival records.

AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

While researching Orakzai history, I learned that finding a record is only the beginning. A document can open a door, but we still have to ask who built the door, why it was built, and what lies beyond it. Colonial records preserve important traces of the past, but they were written from particular positions of power. Local memories preserve another dimension—family stories, names, and places that may never have entered an official archive. Neither source should automatically silence the other. The responsibility is to compare them, to

question them, and to be honest about what remains unknown. For me, historical research is not the art of making every gap disappear; it is the discipline of knowing where the evidence ends.

“THE RECORD IS NOT THE PAST. IT IS A TRACE OF THE PAST.”

METHODOLOGICAL PRINCIPLE
